



The arrival of Netflix in India promises to revolutionise the way we watch TV and Movies

is smart enough to know that Mondays are more depressing than Fridays. In this article, we take an amateur's look at the big data analysis and latent machine learning that goes on behind the scenes of the world's favourite couch potato website.

The Netflix prize – Tiny details lead to big results

Much of the hullabaloo around the recommendation system used by Netflix started when the company announced a \$1M prize to any team of data scientists who could predict user ratings for films purely from the history of previous ratings by the user with an accuracy of at least 10% more than Netflix's existing predictor system in 2006, Cinematch. When it was announced, the prize was not viewed as something that would be taken too seriously. In fact, the CEO of Netflix at the time, Reed Hastings admitted he wasn't expecting much from it and he was so confident in Cinematch that he once admitted that they 'thought we built the best darn thing ever.' However, in a matter of just six days, Cinematch was beaten by an algorithm by team WXYZ Consulting. After that the competition became intense for a period of three years, and, in June 2009, the team that called itself 'Bellkor's Pragmatic Chaos', reported a 10.10% improvement over Cinematch and were crowned winners of the contest.

The incredible part of the entries for the contest was the manner in which they quantified what may seem like very arbitrary and unquantifiable metrics. The Bellkor algorithm took into consideration two key ideas. Firstly, they divided the data set into slices that they called 'frequencies'. These frequencies were then grouped together and sorted based on the quantity of